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Cosmetics

10.6 Cosmetics

Oil: See [1.10.5 Anointing oil<REALIA:1.10.5>](#); [1.15.1 Oil, ointment<REALIA:1.15.1>](#); [9.3 Olive oil<REALIA:9.3>](#).

Perfumes

10.6.1 Perfumes

References:

Hebrew מִרְקָחַת, רִקְחָה, רִקְחָה, רִקְחָה, רִקְחָה (raqach (verb), reqach, roqach, riquach, mirqachath) [EXO 30:25](#), [EXO 30:25](#), [EXO 30:25](#), [EXO 30:35](#), [EXO 30:35](#), [EXO 37:29](#), [1SA 8:13](#), [1CH 9:30](#), [1CH 9:30](#), [2CH 16:14](#), [2CH 16:14](#), [NEH 3:8](#), [ECC 10:1](#), [SNG 8:2](#), [ISA 57:9](#)

Hebrew שֶׁמֶן (shemen) [2SA 14:2](#), [PRO 27:9](#), [ECC 7:1](#), [ECC 9:8](#), [ECC 10:1](#), [SNG 1:3](#), [SNG 1:3](#), [SNG 4:10](#), [ISA 57:9](#), [ISA 61:3](#), [EZE 16:9](#), [MIC 6:15](#)

Greek ἔδυσμα (ēdusma) [ESG 4:17](#)

Description:

Perfumes were specially produced mixtures of pleasant-smelling spices usually added to an oil base. They were used to cover unpleasant smells such as human perspiration, decaying bodies, or even the bloody results of ritual slaughter.

Translation:

The Hebrew verb *raqach* means “to mix, compound,” while the Hebrew word *shemen* means “oil.”

Myrrh

10.6.1.1 Myrrh

References:

Hebrew לוֹט (lot) [GEN 37:25](#), [GEN 43:11](#)

Hebrew מֹר (mor) [EXO 30:23](#), [EST 2:12](#), [PSA 45:9](#), [PRO 7:17](#), [SNG 1:13](#), [SNG 3:6](#), [SNG 4:6](#), [SNG 4:14](#), [SNG 5:1](#), [SNG 5:5](#), [SNG 5:5](#), [SNG 5:13](#)

Greek μυροβρεχής (murobrechēs) [3MA 4:6](#)

Greek μύρον (muron) [MAT 26:7](#), [MAT 26:12](#), [MRK 14:3](#), [MRK 14:4](#), [LUK 7:38](#), [LUK 7:46](#), [JHN 11:2](#), [JHN 12:3](#), [JHN 12:3](#), [JHN 12:5](#), [REV 18:13](#), [JDT 10:3](#), [WIS 2:7](#)

Greek σμύρνα, σμυρνίζω (smurna, smurnizō (verb)) [MAT 2:11](#), [MRK 15:23](#), [SIR 24:15](#)

Description and usage:

Myrrh was the aromatic resin of certain bushes. This resin was added to an oil base to make a perfume to put on the body. See also [4.8.3.1 Embalming oils<REALIA:4.8.3.1>](#).

Translation:

The tree that produced the myrrh resin was not native to Israel, and the import of myrrh made it an expensive luxury. This should be borne in mind when translating [EST 2:12](#); [PSA 45:9](#); [PRO 7:17](#); [SNG 1:13](#); [MAT 2:11](#).

Most translators borrow a term for “myrrh.” In some passages translators may expand the translation to indicate the nature of the substance; compare GNT at [PSA 45:9](#), where it says “perfume of myrrh.” In many instances, particularly in the New Testament, they may use a general expression such as “ointment,” “aromatic oil,” or “perfume.” When the Greek word *muron* means “perfume,” it may be rendered “sweet-smelling oil” or “fragrant oil.”

Oil of nard

10.6.1.2 Oil of nard

References:

Hebrew נֶרְדָּ (nerd) [SNG 1:12](#), [SNG 4:13](#), [SNG 4:14](#)

Greek νάρδος (nardos) [MRK 14:3](#), [JHN 12:3](#)

Description:

Oil of nard was an aromatic oil extracted from a plant called nard.

Translation:

Translators normally borrow the term “nard” but use some type of classifier, for example, “perfume called nard” or “sweet-smelling substance, nard.” For other issues related to the above verses, see also [5.18.1.3 Alabaster jar, alabaster flask<REALIA:5.18.1.3>](#).